

CRESTED GECKO · CORRELOPHUS CILIATUS

# The reptile you can overheat, and how not to.

A complete, fact-checked printable manual: vertical space, the humidity cycle, the 85°F ceiling, complete-diet feeding, health triage, and the routines that keep a crested gecko thriving for its full lifespan.

## INSIDE

- ✓ Temperature ceiling and humidity cycle in °F and °C
- ✓ Complete diet, insect and safe-fruit charts
- ✓ MBD, floppy tail and impaction triage, plus a symptom table
- ✓ Owner logs, pet-sitter sheet, outage and heatwave plans

34 pages

Beginner

Print or tablet

Version 2.1 · Sep 2026



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Every page is written to be used, not just read once.

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## START HERE

# How to use this package

Three ways to get value from it, depending on where you are right now.

## If you haven't set up yet

Read pages 4 through 12 in order before buying anything. Two decisions on page 5 and page 6 shape everything else: how tall the enclosure is, and how you will keep the room under 85°F (29°C) in the hottest week of the year. Then use the Budget & Shopping List on page 24 to buy once.

## If your crested gecko is already set up

Jump to the Setup Checklist and Targets on page 22 to audit what you have, and the Health Red Flags section starting on page 16 if anything seems off. Check the hygrometer and the top-of-enclosure temperature first: nearly every problem in Section 03 traces back to humidity, heat, or substrate.

## Print these first

- |                                                                    |                                                                   |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <input type="checkbox"/> Page 22: Setup Checklist & Targets        | <input type="checkbox"/> Page 29: Pet-Sitter Sheet                |
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### WHY THIS PACKAGE EXISTS

Crested geckos are usually someone's first reptile, and most reptile advice is written around the opposite problem. Nearly every care sheet a new keeper reads is about providing enough heat. Here the danger runs the other way, and a summer afternoon in a sunny room is a bigger risk than a cool night. Cross-checked against veterinary and herpetological sources (listed on page 34), not recycled forum advice. Every temperature and dimension is given in both imperial and metric.

### NOT A SUBSTITUTE FOR

A reptile-experienced veterinarian. This is a husbandry reference for day-to-day care. Anything urgent or health-related is always a professional call, not a page in this book. Find one before you need one and write the number on page 23.

## SECTION 01

# Quick profile

Everything at a glance before you read the detail.

|                           |                                                                                           |
|---------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Scientific name           | <i>Correlophus ciliatus</i>                                                               |
| Adult size                | 7 to 9 in (18 to 23 cm) including tail, 35 to 55 g. Sources give 5 to 8 in and 35 to 45 g |
| Captive lifespan          | 15 to 20 years typical, some past 20, with the earliest captives into their 30s           |
| Native range              | New Caledonia, South Pacific. Tropical rainforest canopy and understory                   |
| Diet type                 | Frugivorous omnivore. A complete diet powder is the base, insects are a supplement        |
| Enclosure minimum (adult) | 18×18×24 in (46×46×61 cm), height over floor space                                        |
| Temperature ceiling       | 85°F (29°C). A hard maximum, not a target                                                 |
| Humidity                  | 60 to 80%, falling to 40 to 50% during the day                                            |
| Sexual maturity           | 15 to 18 months                                                                           |
| Handling difficulty       | Easy once settled, but the tail never grows back. See page 8                              |
| Conservation status       | Vulnerable (IUCN)                                                                         |

## Cost overview

### Initial setup

\$335 to \$530 for equipment, plus \$65 to \$210 for the first vet exam and fecal test. The gecko itself is \$50 to \$200 for a normal morph.

### Monthly ongoing

\$31 to \$52 for diet powder, insects, substrate, electricity and averaged vet care.

### BUDGET FOR THE WORST CASE TOO

A first exam with a fecal test runs \$65 to \$210, and that is the routine number. Diagnostics, x-rays for a suspected impaction, or treatment for advanced metabolic bone disease all cost considerably more, and none are optional once needed. Treat a few hundred dollars set aside as part of the setup.

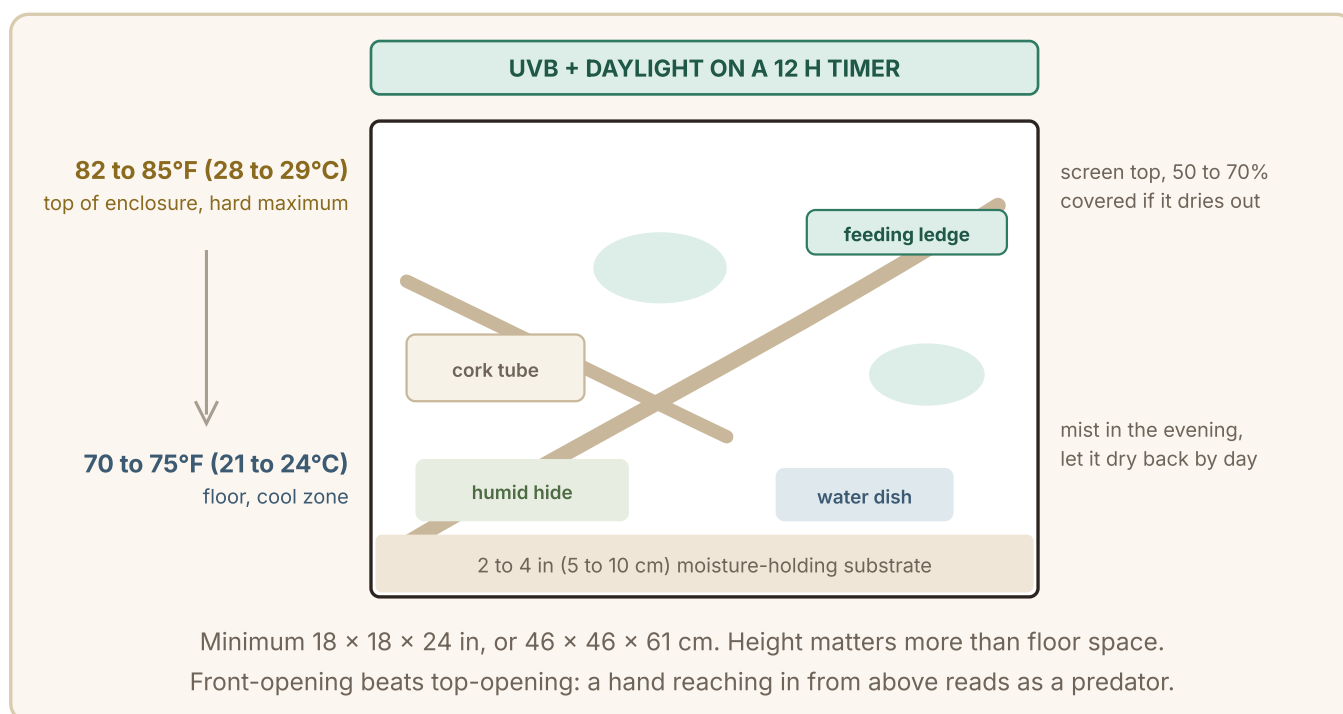
## Fun facts worth knowing

- Thought extinct for most of a century, until a 1994 expedition found them again in New Caledonia during a tropical storm. Every crested gecko in the pet trade descends from that rediscovered population.
- They cannot regrow a dropped tail. Most wild adults are found tailless, and a tailless gecko, a "frogbutt" to keepers, lives an entirely normal life.
- They are one of the few reptiles whose complete nutrition comes out of a jar: a powdered diet mixed with water covers protein, fruit, calcium and D3 in one.

## Housing & enclosure

18×18×24 in (46×46×61 cm) is the minimum for one adult, and taller is genuinely better: a 2×2×2 ft (61×61×61 cm) enclosure is the common upgrade. Crested geckos are arboreal and spend almost all their time off the ground, so height is worth more than floor space. Hatchlings under about 10 to 13 g do better in a smaller grow-out enclosure first, where they can find food and you can find them.

Front-opening glass or PVC holds humidity better than a top-opening tank, and matters for a second reason: reaching in from above is what a predator does. A door at eye level makes every interaction less threatening. House crested geckos singly. Never put two males together, and do not group hatchlings, which bite each other's tails, and those tails do not grow back.



### NEVER

House two males together, and never let the enclosure sit in direct sun or against a radiator. This species dies of heat far more often than of cold, and a sealed glass box in a sunny window climbs past the ceiling in under an hour.

## What the diagram doesn't show

- Anchor every branch and piece of cork properly. A crested gecko jumps between perches on purpose, and a perch that shifts mid-jump is how a tail gets trapped or dropped.
- Height is only useful if it is furnished. A tall, empty enclosure is worse than a shorter one packed with cork, vines and foliage.
- Leave real gaps between perches. Open space is part of a working climbing network for this species, not a design flaw.

# Temperature, humidity & the 85°F ceiling

| ZONE                          | TARGET (°F)                                    | TARGET (°C) |
|-------------------------------|------------------------------------------------|-------------|
| Ambient, daytime              | 72 to 78                                       | 22 to 26    |
| Top of the enclosure          | 82 to 85                                       | 28 to 29    |
| Floor, cool zone              | 70 to 75                                       | 21 to 24    |
| Night                         | 65 to 72                                       | 18 to 22    |
| <b>Hard maximum, anywhere</b> | <b>85</b>                                      | <b>29</b>   |
| Humidity                      | 60 to 80%, falling to 40 to 50% during the day |             |

Measure with digital probes placed mid-enclosure, away from the misting point. Analog dials are inaccurate enough to be worse than nothing, and a small enclosure swings faster than a large one.

## The ceiling is the whole story

Crested geckos come from New Caledonian forest that only reaches 79 to 85°F (26 to 29°C) even in the hot season, and prolonged exposure above that risks fatal heat stroke. Most reptile keeping is about adding heat; this species is the exception, and it catches out anyone coming from a bearded dragon. Some veterinary sources are more conservative still and warn against sustained exposure over 80°F (27°C), so treat 85°F as a wall rather than a target. Most homes sit in range unaided: the summer equipment that matters is a fan or a blind, not a bulb.

Cold is the milder failure, but not nothing: sustained temperatures at or below about 72°F (22°C) day and night bring on lethargy and a dropped appetite. If a room runs cold, a low-wattage bulb on a thermostat, outside the enclosure and aimed at the top third, is the fix.

## Humidity: a cycle, not a number

The target is a daily swing, not a constant reading: 60 to 80% after the evening misting, back down to around 40 to 50% during the day. That cycle mirrors the native climate and keeps sheds clean without breeding mold. A permanently soaked enclosure with no dry phase encourages mold, bacterial growth and respiratory infection, so ventilation matters as much as misting. Page 7 covers holding the cycle in practice.

## Signs your setup needs adjusting

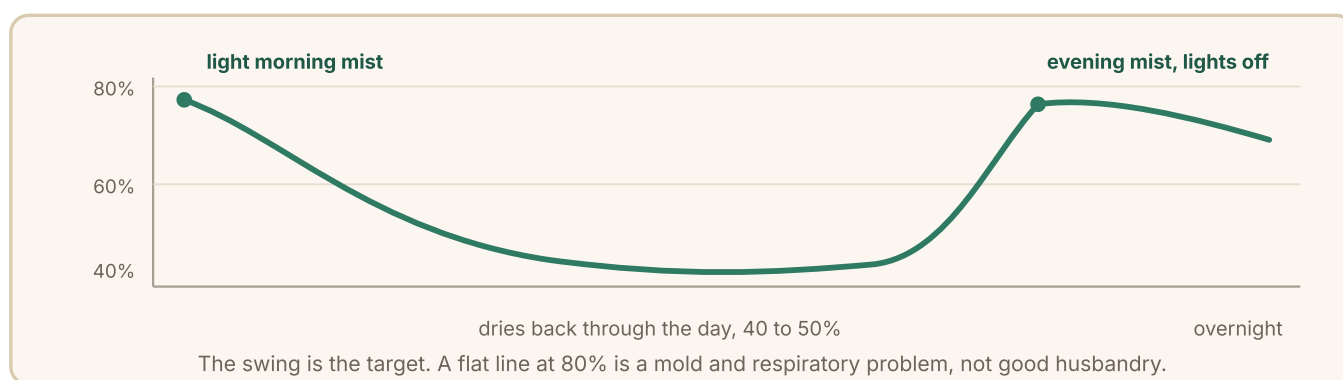
| YOU NOTICE                                                 | LIKELY MEANS                                                                               |
|------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Gecko low on the cool glass, open-mouthed, lethargic       | Too hot. Check the top of the enclosure immediately; this is the emergency direction       |
| Shed stuck on toes or the tail tip                         | Humidity dropping too low or for too long. Check the evening peak, not the daytime reading |
| Condensation all day, a musty smell, mold on the substrate | No dry phase. Increase ventilation and mist less, not more                                 |
| Gecko sluggish, not eating, hiding low for weeks           | Sustained temperature at or below 72°F (22°C), or a seasonal slowdown (page 20)            |

## Misting, ventilation & lighting

### Holding the humidity cycle

Mist once or twice a day, aiming at the walls, plants and cork rather than at the gecko, with the main misting in the evening as the lights go off. Most of a crested gecko's water intake is droplets licked off leaves and glass, so the evening mist is a drink as much as a humidity event. A moisture-holding substrate 2 to 4 in (5 to 10 cm) deep does the slow half of the work, live or good artificial plants hold surface moisture, and live plants add their own through transpiration, which smooths the swing between mistings.

If the enclosure dries out too fast, a screen top is usually why: cover 50 to 70% of it with glass or acrylic before you start misting more often. If it never dries, do the opposite. An automatic mister or fogger on a timer removes the inconsistency of hand spraying, but check it against the hygrometer daily for the first couple of weeks, because a timer that is slightly wrong is worse than a person who is occasionally late.



### Lighting and UVB

UVB is not strictly required, because a complete diet powder already supplies vitamin D3, but low output is still worth providing and is what reptile vets now recommend. Use a low-output T5 HO tube in the 5% to 6% range, 18 to 24 in (46 to 61 cm) long, mounted above the screen over the upper third, targeting a UVI of roughly 1.0 to 2.0 at the highest perch the gecko actually uses. Run a 12 hour photoperiod on a timer, and skip colored night bulbs entirely: a night light is a sleep problem for a crepuscular animal, not a heat solution. Replace the tube every 12 months even if it still lights.

### Ventilation is half of humidity

Every fix here has a mirror image. Covering the screen top raises humidity and slows drying; uncovering it does the reverse. If the readings are wrong, change one thing at a time and wait two days, because a change made this evening does not show its real effect until the next afternoon's dry-back. Chasing the number with the spray bottle instead is how an enclosure ends up permanently soaked.

#### MEASURE, DON'T ASSUME

Put the hygrometer probe mid-enclosure, away from where you spray, and read it twice: once an hour after the evening mist, and once in the middle of the following afternoon. Those two numbers are the cycle. A single reading taken whenever you happen to walk past tells you almost nothing.

# Substrate, furnishings & handling

## Substrate

Paper towel is right for hatchlings and quarantine: it removes impaction risk and makes a stool check trivial. For adults, coconut fiber, sphagnum or a bioactive soil mix hold humidity far better. Keep it 2 to 4 in (5 to 10 cm) deep, spot-clean daily, and do a full change monthly, or every 3 to 4 months for an established bioactive setup.

### NEVER

Sand, or large bark chips, under a young gecko. Loose particulate substrate is a leading cause of impaction in geckos generally, and a hatchling that misses an insect and gets a mouthful of bark is the usual way it happens.

## Furnishings checklist

- ☐ Cork tubes and rounds, which double as daytime sleeping hollows
- ☐ Branches and vines at varied heights, angles and diameters
- ☐ Dense live or artificial foliage for daytime cover
- ☐ An elevated feeding ledge, since they feed off the ground in the wild
- ☐ A humid hide lined with damp sphagnum moss
- ☐ A shallow water dish, refreshed daily

## Handling

Leave a new arrival alone for about two weeks, until it is settled and eating. Wait for a sub-adult or older juvenile, roughly 8 to 15 g, about 4 to 5 in (10 to 13 cm) and six months, before regular handling; under about 10 g they are too fragile. Start with sessions of 1 to 2 minutes every other day, build gradually to around 15 minutes, and keep total daily handling under about 20 minutes even in a tame adult. Evening works best. Let the gecko walk onto your hand rather than grabbing it, and use "treadmilling": cup your free hand in front as it reaches the edge of the other, and it hops hand to hand on its own.

- **A crested gecko's tail does not grow back.** Never grab or restrain it. Stay low over a bed, couch or lap, because they jump readily and a hard floor is a real injury risk.
- Tail-wagging or whipping, squeaking, erratic jumping, gaping, eyes closed, or actively fleeing all mean the session is over. Skittish, rushed handling is exactly what causes a tail drop.

### SALMONELLA

Healthy reptiles shed *Salmonella* without being ill, and one negative test clears nothing. Not a turtle problem: a CDC investigation into pet-gecko infections, closed January 2026, counted 113 cases across 36 states. Wash with soap after every contact with the gecko or its tank. Never clean gear in a kitchen sink, a bathroom sink or a bath people use; keep a plastic tub for it. Do not kiss the gecko. Under-fives, over-65s, pregnancy and a weakened immune system are the risk groups; the CDC line for under-fives is not to handle reptiles at all.

## First days in a new home

Run the enclosure for a day or two first and confirm the humidity cycle and the top-of-enclosure temperature. Then leave the gecko alone for two weeks apart from misting, fresh food and a daily look. Offer diet powder on the normal schedule even if it goes untouched, and treat early refusals as normal.

## Diet & feeding by age

The biggest feeding mistake with this species is treating live insects as the main event. A complete crested gecko diet powder, mixed with water, is the nutritional foundation; insects are a supplement for protein variety and the enrichment of hunting. Introduce insects before the powder is reliably eaten and a gecko can learn to hold out for them, which is a real route to malnutrition.

| AGE                                    | COMPLETE DIET POWDER     | INSECTS             | FEEDINGS          | HOW MUCH                                     |
|----------------------------------------|--------------------------|---------------------|-------------------|----------------------------------------------|
| Hatchling and juvenile, 0 to 12 months | Fresh, daily             | 1 to 2 times a week | Daily             | About 1/2 tsp mixed powder                   |
| Adult, 12 months and up                | Fresh, every 2 to 3 days | About once a week   | Every 2 to 3 days | About 1 tsp mixed powder                     |
| Gravid or recently laid female         | Fresh, daily             | 1 to 2 times a week | Daily             | Adult portion, plus a permanent calcium dish |

Mix the powder with water to a smooth, ketchup-like consistency and serve it in a raised dish on a ledge, since these geckos feed off the ground. Remove and refresh prepared food within 24 to 48 hours to prevent mold; some keepers offer only what is cleared in about four hours. Insects should be no wider than the gecko's head, and anything not eaten within 15 to 20 minutes comes back out so it cannot nip a sleeping gecko overnight.

## Supplement schedule

| SUPPLEMENT                                    | JUVENILE                      | ADULT                   | NOTES                                                                                                                      |
|-----------------------------------------------|-------------------------------|-------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Plain calcium</b> (no D3, phosphorus-free) | On most insect feedings       | On most insect feedings | This is for the insects, which are calcium-poor. The diet powder already carries calcium, so nothing goes into the powder. |
| <b>Calcium with D3</b>                        | 1 to 2 insect feedings a week | About once a week       | A top-up on insect meals only. A complete powder already supplies D3, so this is not a daily dusting.                      |
| <b>Multivitamin</b>                           | 1 to 2 times a week           | Once or twice a week    | Covers vitamin A, which matters for shedding and eyes. Use in place of that feeding's calcium, not on top of it.           |

### DON'T STACK SUPPLEMENTS ONTO A COMPLETE DIET

A crested gecko diet powder is formulated to be nutritionally complete on its own, calcium and vitamin D3 included. Dusting powder into it, or dusting D3 onto every insect on top of it, is not extra insurance: D3 is fat-soluble and accumulates. Supplement the insects, not the powder.

## Water

A shallow dish of fresh dechlorinated water, refreshed daily and scrubbed weekly, plus the droplets from misting, where most of the drinking happens. Water runs on a shorter clock than food: about three days.

### NEVER FEED

Avocado, citrus fruit, rhubarb, onion, garlic, eggplant, fireflies, or any wild-caught insect. The full never-feed list is on page 12.

## Complete diet powder: mixing, portions & rotation

The base of the diet. Get this right and the rest of the food pages are extras.

| FOOD                                                  | TIER       | NOTES                                                                                                                                                               |
|-------------------------------------------------------|------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Complete crested gecko diet powder (Pangea, Repashy)  | STAPLE     | A meal replacement mixed with water, supplying protein, fruit, calcium and vitamin D3 in one product. Unusual among reptiles: this alone is nutritionally complete. |
| A second and third flavor or brand, rotated           | STAPLE     | Rotate 2 to 3, for variety and because crested geckos are genuinely picky. Watermelon is the flavor repeatedly named as unusually well accepted by fussy eaters.    |
| Pureed fruit offered alongside the powder             | OCCASIONAL | Mashed, never chunks, and alongside rather than instead. Too often and a gecko starts rejecting the food that is actually complete. Page 12 has the safe list.      |
| Baby food, honey, or a homemade fruit mix as the base | NEVER      | Not nutritionally complete, and they teach a gecko to hold out for something sweeter than its real food.                                                            |
| Dog food, cat food, or human leftovers                | NEVER      | Wrong protein, wrong minerals, wrong animal.                                                                                                                        |

### Mixing and serving

- Mix powder with water to a smooth, ketchup-like consistency. Thicker than a sauce, thinner than a paste.
- Serve in a shallow raised dish on a ledge or a magnetic wall feeder. Crested geckos feed arboreally and many will not come down to a floor dish.
- About 1/2 teaspoon of mixed diet for a juvenile, about 1 teaspoon for an adult, adjusted by how much actually gets eaten.
- Remove and refresh within 24 to 48 hours to prevent mold. Some keepers offer only what is cleared within about four hours, especially in a warm room.
- Mix fresh each time rather than storing made-up diet. Dry powder keeps; wet diet does not.

### When a gecko refuses its powder

Pickiness is the first thing to rule out, not the last: crested geckos are fussier than most keepers expect and will reject one flavor or texture while eating another happily. Rotating two or three brands or flavors is the standard fix. Look at the husbandry next, since heat above the ceiling and humidity outside the 60 to 80% range both suppress appetite. Only then treat it as a health question, and page 12 has the thresholds that decide when.

#### DON'T START WITH INSECTS

Get a new gecko reliably eating its complete diet before offering any live insect. A gecko that learns insects arrive if it holds out will refuse the powder, and the powder is the part carrying the nutrition. Insects are the extra, in both directions.

# Feeder insects: staples, treats & never

A supplement, once or twice a week, not the base diet. Commercially raised, gut-loaded and dusted.

| INSECT                                | TIER       | NOTES                                                                                                                                |
|---------------------------------------|------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Dubia roaches                         | STAPLE     | The best of the group: good protein, lower fat, easy to gut-load, quiet, and they cannot climb smooth plastic.                       |
| Discoid roaches                       | STAPLE     | The usual substitute where dubia are restricted, and interchangeable with them.                                                      |
| Crickets                              | STAPLE     | Cheap and active, which brings out real stalking. Remove any not eaten within 15 to 20 minutes: loose crickets nip a sleeping gecko. |
| Black soldier fly larvae (calciworms) | STAPLE     | The one common feeder that is not calcium-poor, carrying calcium in the exoskeleton. Small and soft, which suits juveniles.          |
| Hornworms (captive-bred only)         | OCCASIONAL | Mostly water, so useful for a gecko that is off food or looking dry. They grow fast, so re-check the size every day.                 |
| Mealworms                             | OCCASIONAL | Fatty, with a hard shell. Fine in rotation, poor as a regular, and not for a small juvenile.                                         |
| Waxworms                              | TREAT ONLY | Very high fat and habit-forming. A couple at a time, rarely, and never as a way to tempt a picky gecko into eating.                  |
| Fireflies and lightning bugs          | NEVER      | Treated as toxic to reptiles generally. This is not a moderation issue.                                                              |
| Any wild-caught insect                | NEVER      | Pesticide and parasite risk, however clean the garden looks.                                                                         |

## Gut-loading and dusting

Feeder insects are poor calcium sources, and the problem is the ratio rather than the amount: unsupplemented crickets sit near 1 part calcium to 9 parts phosphorus when the target is closer to 2:1. Feed insects a genuinely calcium-rich diet for 24 to 48 hours before offering them, a commercial gut-load sold on its calcium content, or collard, mustard, turnip or dandelion greens and butternut squash. Carrot and potato keep insects alive but do nothing for the ratio. Avoid spinach, beet greens and chard, which are high in oxalic acid and bind the calcium they contain. Then dust lightly with calcium before each insect feeding, per the schedule on page 9.

### SIZE RULE

No insect wider than the widest part of the gecko's head, which for a small gecko means the space between the eyes. Oversized prey is one of the three usual impaction causes in this species, alongside loose substrate and shed skin that was never fully passed.

## Fruit, extras & the never-feed list

Treats sit alongside the complete diet, never in place of it.

| FOOD                                  | TIER       | NOTES                                                                                                                                                                  |
|---------------------------------------|------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Banana, mango, papaya, apricot, peach | OCCASIONAL | Pureed or well mashed, offered alongside the powder. A small smear, not a meal.                                                                                        |
| Melon and soft berries                | OCCASIONAL | Same rule. High water content, readily taken, easy to overdo.                                                                                                          |
| Raspberries                           | DISPUTED   | A genuine disagreement between sources: some list them as a safe treat, others flag them as high-oxalate. Worth knowing rather than treating either answer as settled. |
| Avocado                               | NEVER      | Toxic. No amount is a safe amount.                                                                                                                                     |
| Citrus fruit                          | NEVER      | The acidity interferes with calcium absorption, which is the last thing this species needs.                                                                            |
| Rhubarb                               | NEVER      | Toxic.                                                                                                                                                                 |
| Onion, garlic, eggplant               | NEVER      | All three are flagged as unsafe for crested geckos.                                                                                                                    |

### Extras and "human food" questions

| ITEM                                   | VERDICT | NOTES                                                                            |
|----------------------------------------|---------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Baby food (fruit), honey, jam          | NEVER   | Sugar without the nutrition, and it teaches a gecko to refuse its complete diet. |
| Vitamin drops in the water dish        | NEVER   | Uncontrolled dosing, and it fouls the water. Supplements go on insects.          |
| Insects from the garden or a bait shop | NEVER   | Pesticides, parasites, and no way to know what they ate.                         |

### When a refusal becomes a vet visit

A healthy adult at a good weight can typically go about 2 to 3 weeks without eating, though a vet consult is worth considering after the second week, especially with visible weight loss. Juveniles have far less reserve: a young gecko refusing food for more than a few days is more urgent than an adult doing the same. Water runs on a much shorter clock, about three days. Go regardless of the day count for visible weight loss, a bony spine, hip or tail base, sunken eyes, lethargy or lost grip strength, or a soft, rubbery lower jaw, which is a metabolic bone disease sign.

#### THE NEVER-FEED LIST, IN ONE PLACE

Avocado. Citrus fruit. Rhubarb. Onion, garlic and eggplant. Fireflies and lightning bugs. Any wild-caught insect. Baby food, honey or homemade fruit mixes as a diet base. Dog and cat food. Anything wider than the widest part of the gecko's head.

# Common mistakes & enrichment

## Mistakes that cause the most harm

- **Treating heat like a bearded dragon's.** A basking bulb aimed into a small glass enclosure, or a tank in a sunny window, can push past 85°F (29°C) in an afternoon. Prolonged exposure above that risks fatal heat stroke.
- **Insects as the main diet.** A gecko that has learned to hold out for insects will refuse its complete powder, and the powder is where the calcium and D3 are.
- **A tall enclosure with nothing in it.** Vertical space only counts once it is furnished. Empty height is floor space the gecko cannot use.

## Enrichment, by priority

Enrichment comes after correct temperature, humidity and a properly sized vertical enclosure, never instead of them. In this order:

### 1. A real climbing network

The single highest-impact upgrade for this species. Cork tubes and rounds, branches at varied diameters and angles, vines woven into crossing routes, and elevated ledges. Leave genuine gaps between perches: crested geckos are confident jumpers and use open space on purpose.

### 2. Cover at height

Dense foliage, live or good artificial, lets a gecko control its own light exposure during the day. Pothos, philodendron, sansevieria and bromeliads are common safe choices. A gecko with nowhere to hide is a stressed gecko.

### 3. Elevated, varied feeding

Move the dish between ledges rather than using the same spot forever, and tuck small amounts among the foliage. Matching where the animal naturally feeds costs nothing and changes how much of the enclosure it uses.

### 4. Live hunting, once or twice a week

Insects bring out stalking and pursuit that a dish of powder cannot. This is the enrichment argument for feeding insects at all, given the powder already covers nutrition.

### 5. A bioactive setup

Springtails and isopods working through a drainage layer, soil mix and leaf litter add continuous low-level stimulation and reduce how often you intervene. A long-term option once the basics are dialed in, not a requirement.

### 6. Small changes, not overhauls

Rearranging a shy gecko's whole enclosure causes stress rather than enrichment. Change a branch angle or rotate a plant; leave the core climbing structure and the hides where they are.

## Sexing, growth & body condition

### Telling male from female

Two features, both at the vent, and both readable only as the gecko approaches maturity at 15 to 18 months. **Males** develop a pair of hemipenal bulges at the tail base, just behind the vent, and a row of preanal pores in front of it. **Females** have neither, or only faint pores. Look through the glass from below while the gecko is on the wall rather than restraining it, and never hold the tail for a better angle. Sexing a hatchling is guesswork whatever the shop says.

### Growth reference

Crested geckos are tracked by weight rather than length, because a gram scale is precise and a wriggling arboreal gecko is not. Weigh weekly and log it on page 30; weight change is usually the first sign that anything is wrong.

| STAGE                     | WHAT CHANGES AT THIS STAGE                                                           | WEIGHT                                           |
|---------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------|
| Hatchling                 | Grow-out enclosure, paper towel, daily diet powder. Too fragile for routine handling | Under about 10 g                                 |
| Juvenile, around 6 months | Handling can begin, 1 to 2 minutes at a time, once settled and eating                | 8 to 15 g, about 4 to 5 in (10 to 13 cm)         |
| Sub-adult                 | Ready for the full adult enclosure                                                   | About 10 g and up                                |
| Adult, 15 to 18 months    | Sexually mature, fully grown, adult feeding schedule                                 | 35 to 55 g, 7 to 9 in (18 to 23 cm) total length |

Sources differ on the adult figures: 35 to 45 g and about 8 in (20 cm) in one species reference, 5 to 8 in (13 to 20 cm) in a veterinary care sheet, 35 to 55 g and 7 to 9 in elsewhere. The spread is the real answer, not a target.

### Body condition at a glance

#### UNDERWEIGHT

Spine, hip bones or tail base standing out sharply, sunken eyes, loose grip when it walks across your hand. Check the diet powder is actually being eaten rather than dried out in the dish, then look at temperature, humidity and parasites (page 19).

#### IDEAL

A smooth line over the hips and spine with the bones felt rather than seen, a full tail base if the tail is present, a firm grip, and weight that is stable in an adult or climbing steadily in a juvenile.

#### OVERWEIGHT

Less common here than in leopard geckos, because the diet is controlled. It shows as a broad, heavy body and reluctance to climb, usually from too much fruit or too many waxworms. Cut the treats, not the complete diet.

#### WHEN A WEIGHT CHANGE IS A VET VISIT

Any steady loss across three or four weekly weigh-ins, a juvenile that stops gaining, or a female losing weight beyond the dip that follows laying. A gram scale is the most useful tool you can own for this species: weight moves well before anything else looks wrong. Bring the Owner Log, because a trend line tells a vet more than a single reading.

## Females, eggs & egg binding

A female kept entirely alone can still produce eggs. This page is for every female owner, not just breeders.

### Eggs without a male

Female egg-laying reptiles can produce eggs with no male present, which means every female is at risk of being unable to pass one. In this species the cycle runs through much of the year, with clutches roughly every 4 to 6 weeks, and each one draws on her calcium reserves. Gravid females often look visibly plump and less active, and appetite can dip for a week or more before laying. A female housed with a male is the higher-risk case rather than the normal one: pairs left together beyond a short breeding window can leave the female over-bred and calcium-crashed, which is why single housing is the default recommendation.

### Signs a female is gravid or about to lay

- A visibly fuller, heavier abdomen, sometimes with two pale oval shapes discernible through the skin.
- Restlessness and repeated digging in the substrate, often at night and often in a corner.
- Appetite falling off for several days beforehand, then returning once she has laid.

### Give her somewhere to lay

Inadequate nesting is a recognized cause of egg retention in lizards, and it is the easiest cause to remove. Put a lay box in as soon as she looks gravid: a tub with an entry hole in the lid, filled 3 to 4 in (8 to 10 cm) deep with damp coco fiber or damp sphagnum, damp enough to hold a burrow shape without being wet, placed low in the enclosure. Then leave her to it. Disturbance during laying is exactly what makes a female hold on to eggs.

#### CALCIUM IS THE OTHER HALF

A laying female is spending calcium faster than the rest of the year. Keep a shallow dish of plain calcium in the enclosure for her to self-regulate from, keep the complete diet available daily rather than every 2 to 3 days, and weigh her before and after each clutch. Repeated clutch after clutch is worth raising with a reptile vet rather than accepting as normal.

### Egg binding (dystocia) is a same-day call

Egg binding is a female straining but unable to pass eggs. Laying should be complete in under 48 hours; past that, or at any point she looks stressed or unwell, it is a vet visit rather than more waiting. Causes include an inadequate nest site, poor calcium status, illness, oversized or misshapen eggs, and incorrect temperature or humidity. Treatment ranges from fixing the nest site through calcium and hormone injections to surgical removal, and the earlier it is caught the further down that list it stops.

- Straining, a swollen cloaca, restlessness that does not settle, repeated digging with nothing produced.
- Lethargy, depression, refusing food while still visibly gravid, or any tissue protruding from the vent, which is an immediate emergency.

# Health red flags

What to watch for, and what to actually tell the vet.

**CONTACT A REPTILE-EXPERIENCED VET PROMPTLY IF YOU SEE**

A soft, rubbery or visibly misaligned lower jaw. Floppy or weak limbs, a kinked spine, tremors, or new difficulty climbing. Open-mouth breathing, wheezing, or visible mucus. No bowel movement for a week or more, or a bloated abdomen with straining. Ongoing weight loss across several weigh-ins. Sunken eyes with repeated stuck sheds. Any tissue protruding from the vent. A gecko found pressed to the cool glass, limp, after the enclosure has been hot.

## What to tell the vet

- ☐ Both humidity readings: an hour after misting, and mid-afternoon
- ☐ The highest temperature the enclosure reached, not just the current reading
- ☐ Substrate, and exactly what the gecko eats, including brand of diet powder
- ☐ When symptoms started and whether they're worsening
- ☐ Last normal bowel movement, and what it looked like
- ☐ Weight trend from the Owner Log, and a fresh stool sample in a sealed bag if you can

## Why husbandry comes up first

Nearly everything on the next four pages traces back to three settings: calcium, humidity and substrate. Metabolic bone disease is a calcium and D3 problem, stuck shed is a humidity problem, impaction is usually a substrate or prey-size problem, and respiratory infection is a cold-and-wet problem. That is why a vet asks about the setup before the symptom, and why an owner who can quote both humidity readings and the enclosure's daily high is already halfway to the answer. The Association of Reptilian and Amphibian Veterinarians keeps a searchable directory of reptile-experienced vets; find one before you need one and write the number on page 23.

## Normal vs. concerning

| NORMAL                                                                      | CONCERNING                                                                       |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Colors dulling for a day or two, then a shed, often eaten before you see it | Shed stuck on toes or the tail tip, or a gecko that has not shed in months       |
| Eating and moving less in winter, with weight holding steady                | The same, with weight dropping across several weeks                              |
| Sleeping pressed against cork or a leaf all day, active after dark          | Sitting low on the cool glass in the day with the mouth open, after a warm spell |

## Metabolic bone disease & floppy tail syndrome

### Metabolic bone disease (MBD)

**Cause:** a deficiency of calcium or vitamin D3, usually from a diet that is not actually a complete diet, or insects fed without dusting. It is progressive, which is why catching it early matters so much. **Signs:** the first thing most owners notice is a soft or rubbery lower jaw. Advanced signs are floppy or weak limbs, a visibly misaligned jaw, a kinked spine, tremors, and difficulty climbing, which in an arboreal species shows up early because the animal simply stops going up. **Diagnosis:** a vet, via bloodwork and x-rays. **Response:** do not wait to see whether a soft jaw gets worse on its own. **Recovery:** caught early and corrected, the outlook is good; once the disease is advanced, some of the damage is permanent even with treatment.

#### THE PREVENTION IS THREE THINGS

Feed a genuinely complete crested gecko diet powder as the base, dust the insects, and provide low-level UVB. That combination makes MBD close to a solved problem in this species, which is exactly why it is so frustrating when it turns up. Check monthly that the diet powder is being eaten and not just served.

### Floppy tail syndrome (FTS)

**Cause:** not fully settled. It is associated with chronic upside-down resting against flat glass, where gravity works on the tail base over months, and it is sometimes linked to calcium status and pelvic changes. **Signs:** the tail hangs over the gecko's head or sits at an odd angle relative to the body when it is resting inverted. **Diagnosis:** visual, with a vet visit worth doing to rule out an underlying calcium problem, since it occasionally overlaps with MBD without being diagnostic of it. **Recovery:** generally benign and irreversible; a gecko with mild FTS lives a normal life. **Prevention:** give the animal somewhere better than bare glass to sleep. Cork tubes, dense foliage and wide branches at height mean it rarely chooses to hang inverted on a flat wall in the first place, and consistent calcium from the start covers the other half.

#### CONCRETE THRESHOLD

A jaw that feels soft or rubbery, any tremor, or a gecko that has stopped climbing when it used to, is a vet appointment this week rather than something to monitor. In the meantime lower the highest perches so a weakened animal cannot fall from height.

## Impaction, stuck shed & respiratory infection

The three husbandry-driven problems, in the order they turn up.

### Impaction

The most common health problem in pet geckos generally, and crested geckos are no exception. It is a blockage of the digestive tract, usually caused by loose substrate such as sand or bark chips, by prey too large to pass, or by shed skin that was never fully passed. Watch for no bowel movement for a week or more, a visibly bloated abdomen, straining, lethargy and appetite loss. Prevent it with solid substrate such as paper towel or tile for young geckos, and by keeping insects no wider than the widest part of the gecko's head. A warm 15 minute soak can help a mild case; if symptoms persist beyond 24 to 48 hours, see a vet, because a true blockage is a surgical problem.

### Retained or stuck shed (dysecdysis)

Almost always a humidity problem, and the toes are where it matters. Shed left as a ring around a toe acts as a tourniquet and can cost the gecko the digit. Fix the humidity cycle first and provide a humid hide with damp sphagnum moss. For shed already stuck, soak the gecko in shallow lukewarm water for 10 to 15 minutes and work the softened skin off with a damp cotton swab, over a couple of sessions rather than forcing it. Never peel dry shed. Shed around the eyes is a vet job, not a home one, and repeated stuck sheds point at dehydration as well as at low humidity.

### Respiratory infection

Caused by an enclosure that is too cold, too wet, or both, which is the failure mode of misting harder to fix a shedding problem. Look for open-mouth breathing, visible mucus, wheezing and lethargy. This needs a vet rather than a wait-and-see, and the husbandry gets fixed at the same time: restore the daily dry-back to 40 to 50%, increase ventilation, and check the enclosure is not sitting below 72°F (22°C) day and night.

#### THE COMMON THREAD

All three are settings rather than bad luck. Impaction traces to substrate and prey size, stuck shed to the humidity cycle, respiratory infection to cold and constant damp. Any gecko showing one of them should have both humidity readings and the enclosure's daily high checked the same day, because the fix usually lives in those numbers.

## Parasites, dehydration, tail loss & overheating

Less dramatic than the last two pages, and far more common.

### Internal parasites and cryptosporidiosis

Internal parasites, and less commonly cryptosporidiosis, are both on the list for this species. Crypto in particular is serious and often difficult to treat, which is the practical reason to have a fecal exam done at the first vet visit rather than waiting for a reason. Loose or foul stool, weight loss with a normal appetite, and a gecko that fails to thrive are the signs worth acting on. Bring a fresh sample in a sealed bag; it turns a routine appointment into a real baseline.

### Dehydration

Shows up as sunken eyes, wrinkled or loose-looking skin, repeated stuck sheds, and reduced activity and appetite. Because most drinking happens off misted surfaces, a missed evening mist matters more here than a stale water dish. Correct the cycle, check the hygrometer rather than trusting the routine, and offer a captive-bred hornworm, which is mostly water. A gecko that stays wrinkled after the humidity is corrected needs a vet.

### Tail loss

Crested geckos drop their tails as a defense response, and unlike leopard geckos **the tail does not grow back**. It happens from fright, rough or rushed handling, a fall, a cagemate, or a tail caught in a lid or door. There is no treatment and no regrowth, so prevention is the whole strategy: calm unhurried handling, never touching the tail, secure perches, and single housing. The good news is that it is not the crisis it sounds like. A tailless gecko, a "frogbutt" to keepers, lives a completely normal life, breeding and climbing unaffected, and most wild adults are tailless too. Keep the enclosure clean while the base heals and watch it for swelling, discharge or a foul smell.

### Overheating

The emergency this species has that most reptiles do not. A gecko sitting low on the cool glass, mouth open, unresponsive or barely gripping after a hot day is a heat casualty until proven otherwise. Move it to a cooler room immediately, keep it out of direct airflow, offer water on a misted surface, and call a vet: heat stroke can be fatal and the damage is not always visible. Then fix the cause, since it is almost always sun on the glass, a bulb that is too close or unregulated, or a room that got away from you in a heatwave. Page 28 covers the plan for that.

### Skin and eye problems

Chronically high humidity combined with poor enclosure hygiene produces skin and scale problems, which is the other reason the dry-back phase matters. Eye issues usually trace to retained shed or a vitamin A deficiency: a gecko holding an eye closed or rubbing its face needs a vet rather than home treatment.

## Shedding, seasonal slowdown & behavior

### The shed cycle

Shedding, properly ecdysis, is how a reptile grows and clears old skin. Juveniles shed roughly every one to two weeks, adults about once a month. Colors go dull and the skin looks dry beforehand, appetite commonly dips for a few days either side, and then the whole thing happens fast, usually at night, and most crested geckos eat the shed as it comes off. Many owners never witness one, which is normal. Humidity is the single biggest factor in whether it comes away cleanly, and rough surfaces, cork and textured branches, give the gecko something to rub against to start the peel.

#### SHED WEEK ROUTINE

Make sure the evening mist actually happens and the humid hide is damp. No handling while a shed is in progress. The morning after, check the toes and the tail tip in good light, and check the eyes. Anything still attached gets a lukewarm soak and a damp swab, never a fingernail.

### Seasonal slowdown, not brumation

Crested geckos are tropical and should never be put through a deliberate cooling cycle the way a temperate species might. That said, keepers do report cresties eating and moving less through the winter months even with stable husbandry, on their own internal rhythm. The rule that keeps it safe is the same as everywhere else in this book: weigh weekly. A slowdown with a steady weight is a season. A slowdown with a falling weight is a health problem wearing a season's clothes.

### Behavior worth recognizing

Crested geckos change color, "firing up" darker and more saturated at night or when active, and "firing down" pale and washed out at rest. Both are normal and neither is a mood reading. They are strong jumpers and will launch from a hand without warning, which is why handling happens low over something soft. Tail-wagging or whipping, squeaking, gaping, erratic jumping and closed eyes during handling all mean the same thing: put the gecko back. A gecko that spends the whole evening on the glass rather than in its climbing structure is usually telling you the enclosure is too sparse, too hot, or both.

#### QUICK DIFFERENTIATOR

A winter slowdown looks like a gecko that eats less and moves less but holds its weight, sheds normally and grips firmly. A health problem looks like the same behavior with weight loss, a soft jaw, sunken eyes or a weak grip. Weight and grip are the two checks that separate them, and both take seconds.

## Reading poop & keeping a gecko hydrated

Stool is the earliest free health check you get. Look at it before you clean it up.

| IT LOOKS LIKE                                                                                                                                                           | USUALLY MEANS                                                  | DO                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| A dark pellet with a soft white urate attached, usually stuck to the glass or a leaf. Softer than a strict insectivore's, because the diet is mostly fruit-based powder | Normal                                                         | Remove it, note it in the log, carry on                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| Runny or foul-smelling for two days or more                                                                                                                             | Parasites, a sudden diet change, or stress                     | Collect a fresh sample in a sealed bag and book a fecal test (page 19)                                                                                                                                                     |
| Nothing at all for a week or more, with a bloated abdomen                                                                                                               | Impaction                                                      | Warm 15 to 20 minute soak; vet if it persists beyond 24 to 48 hours (page 18)                                                                                                                                              |
| Undigested insect parts passed whole                                                                                                                                    | Food moving through too fast, or an enclosure that is too cool | Check the daily temperature range, then vet if it is correct (page 6)                                                                                                                                                      |
| Urate hard and yellow rather than soft and white                                                                                                                        | Dehydration, and left uncorrected a urate or kidney problem    | For an arboreal species the correction is misting, not a water bowl: check both humidity readings, mist on schedule, offer a hornworm (page 19). Persisting is a vet visit, since the same uric acid chemistry causes gout |

### Hydration

A rainforest species drinks mostly by licking droplets, so hydration and humidity are the same subject here. A crested gecko can only go about three days without water, which is a much shorter clock than the two to three weeks it can manage without food.

- The evening mist is the main drink of the day. Coat the leaves, the cork and the glass, not the gecko.
- A shallow water dish, refreshed daily and scrubbed weekly. Many geckos rarely use it, and it still goes in.
- A humid hide with damp sphagnum, and a captive-bred hornworm as the quickest way to get water into a gecko that is looking dry.

#### SIGNS OF DEHYDRATION

Sunken eyes, wrinkled or loose-looking skin, repeated stuck sheds, a weaker grip than usual, and reduced activity and appetite. Correct the humidity cycle first and check the hygrometer rather than assuming the routine is working. A gecko that is still wrinkled a few days after the cycle is right needs a vet, because persistent dehydration usually has something else behind it.

## Setup checklist & targets

### Essential setup checklist

- ☐ 18×18×24 in (46×46×61 cm) front-opening enclosure, taller if possible
- ☐ Coconut fiber, sphagnum or bioactive substrate, 2 to 4 in (5 to 10 cm) deep
- ☐ Cork tubes, branches and vines at varied heights
- ☐ Dense live or artificial foliage for daytime cover
- ☐ Elevated feeding ledge and a shallow water dish
- ☐ Digital probe thermometer and hygrometer, mid-enclosure
- ☐ Fine misting bottle, or a mister on a timer
- ☐ Humid hide with damp sphagnum moss
- ☐ Two or three complete diet powders, plus calcium and a multivitamin
- ☐ Low-output UVB on a 12 hour timer (optional, recommended)

### Temperature & climate targets

| TARGET                        | °F                                                            | °C        |
|-------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------|-----------|
| Ambient, daytime              | 72 to 78                                                      | 22 to 26  |
| Top of the enclosure          | 82 to 85                                                      | 28 to 29  |
| Floor, cool zone              | 70 to 75                                                      | 21 to 24  |
| Night                         | 65 to 72                                                      | 18 to 22  |
| <b>Hard maximum, anywhere</b> | <b>85</b>                                                     | <b>29</b> |
| Humidity                      | 60 to 80% after misting, drying back to 40 to 50% by day      |           |
| Light cycle                   | 12 hours on, 12 hours off, on a timer. No colored night bulbs |           |

### Before your gecko comes home

- ☐ Enclosure running for 48 hours, with the humidity cycle and the daily high both verified
- ☐ Climbing structure anchored, foliage in, feeding ledge mounted
- ☐ Two or three diet powders bought, so a picky gecko has options from day one
- ☐ Reptile vet found and first appointment booked (page 25)

## Emergency & quick targets

### CALL A REPTILE VET NOW IF

The enclosure has been over 85°F (29°C) and the gecko is limp, gaping or unresponsive. The lower jaw is soft or crooked, or the limbs are weak and it has stopped climbing. Breathing is audible, open-mouthed, or there is mucus. No bowel movement for a week or more with a bloated belly. A female has been straining for more than 48 hours. Tissue is protruding from the vent.

| READING                       | °F                                        | °C        |
|-------------------------------|-------------------------------------------|-----------|
| Top of the enclosure          | 82 to 85                                  | 28 to 29  |
| Floor, cool zone              | 70 to 75                                  | 21 to 24  |
| <b>Hard maximum, anywhere</b> | <b>85</b>                                 | <b>29</b> |
| Act below (sustained)         | 72                                        | 22        |
| Humidity                      | 60 to 80% after misting, 40 to 50% by day |           |

### Your numbers

Reptile vet \_\_\_\_\_

UVB bulb installed \_\_\_\_\_

24-hour exotic emergency clinic \_\_\_\_\_

Substrate last changed \_\_\_\_\_

Gecko's name and hatch date \_\_\_\_\_

Last vet visit \_\_\_\_\_

### Routine, written down

Diet powder days \_\_\_\_\_

Misting times \_\_\_\_\_

Insect day \_\_\_\_\_

Lights on and off at \_\_\_\_\_

### HAVE THIS READY WHEN YOU CALL

Current weight in grams and the last three from the log. Both humidity readings and the highest temperature the enclosure has reached in the last few days. Substrate type. Which diet powder, and when it was last eaten. When the gecko last passed stool. A photo of anything visible.

## Budget & shopping list

US retail ranges. The low end is basic but correct gear; the high end is premium equipment.

| INITIAL SETUP                                      | TYPICAL COST          |
|----------------------------------------------------|-----------------------|
| Enclosure, 18×18×24 in (46×46×61 cm), vertical     | \$150 to \$200        |
| Low-output UVB fixture and bulb                    | \$50 to \$80          |
| Low-wattage heat bulb and dome fixture, 25 to 40 W | \$20 to \$40          |
| Thermostat                                         | \$30 to \$35          |
| Substrate                                          | \$15 to \$30          |
| Decor: cork, branches, vines, hides and foliage    | \$45 to \$80          |
| Digital thermometer and hygrometer                 | \$15 to \$25          |
| Fine misting bottle, or a fogger                   | \$10 to \$40          |
| <b>Equipment subtotal</b>                          | <b>\$335 to \$530</b> |
| First vet exam and fecal test                      | \$65 to \$210         |
| <b>All-in before the gecko arrives</b>             | <b>\$400 to \$740</b> |

The gecko itself is separate: \$50 to \$200 for a normal morph, up to \$500 to \$1,000 or more for rare ones. A hatchling can start in a basic grow-out enclosure for around \$20. Many keepers skip the heat bulb and thermostat if the room already sits in range, and most first-time setups land around \$300 to \$600 before the gecko.

| MONTHLY ONGOING                                                  | TYPICAL COST        |
|------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------|
| Complete diet powder (a \$20 bag lasts one adult about 3 months) | About \$7           |
| Occasional live insects                                          | \$5 to \$10         |
| Substrate replacement                                            | About \$10          |
| Electricity                                                      | \$1 to \$5          |
| UVB bulb replacement, averaged over the year                     | \$4 to \$7          |
| Annual vet care, averaged                                        | \$4 to \$13         |
| <b>Monthly ongoing</b>                                           | <b>\$31 to \$52</b> |

Low electricity is this species' budget advantage: no basking bulb all day, often no supplemental heat at all.

### PLAN FOR, DON'T COUNT ON AVOIDING

Diagnostics, x-rays for a suspected impaction, or treatment for advanced metabolic bone disease all cost well beyond a routine exam, and none are optional once needed. A few hundred dollars set aside matters as much as any item here.

### WHERE NOT TO CUT CORNERS

Enclosure height, the climbing structure that makes it usable, and the first vet exam. Decor looks like the optional line and is not: for an arboreal animal it is the difference between an enclosure and a box.

## First 30 days checklist

### Day 1

- ☐ Weigh the gecko in grams and photograph it and the setup for a baseline
- ☐ Confirm the humidity cycle and the daily high before the gecko goes in, then leave it alone
- ☐ Fill in the numbers on page 23 and the equipment dates on page 31

### Week 1

- ☐ No handling at all. Mist on schedule, offer fresh diet powder, remove it within 24 to 48 hours
- ☐ Book a wellness visit with a reptile vet within the first 30 days, and take a fresh stool sample
- ☐ Confirm the gecko is finding the food. If the dish is untouched all week, try a second flavor before worrying

### Week 2 to 3

- ☐ Once it is settled and eating, and above about 8 to 10 g, start 1 to 2 minute handling sessions every other day
- ☐ Watch for the first shed and check toes, tail tip and eyes the morning after
- ☐ Start the Owner Log on page 30 with a weekly weigh-in

### Week 4

- ☐ Review the weight trend. Steady gain is the goal for a juvenile, stable weight for an adult
- ☐ Offer the first live insects, now that the diet powder is reliably being eaten
- ☐ Introduce the first enrichment items from page 32

### Days 31 to 90

- ☐ Book any follow-up the vet recommended, and act on the fecal result rather than filing it
- ☐ If this gecko is joining others, quarantine it in a separate room with its own tools for 3 to 6 months, the Merck figure. A clear fecal is one snapshot of an intermittent process and does not end the window on its own (page 19)
- ☐ Look back at the Owner Log for any slow drift in weight, appetite, or shed quality
- ☐ Start rotating enrichment on the monthly schedule from page 32, and fill in the pet-sitter sheet on page 29 before you need it

## Symptom quick reference

| SYMPTOM                                                 | LIKELY CAUSE                                       | ACTION                                                                 |
|---------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Limp or gaping after a hot spell, low on the cool glass | Overheating                                        | Cool the room now, then vet the same day (page 19)                     |
| Soft or rubbery lower jaw                               | Metabolic bone disease                             | Vet this week; check the diet powder is actually being eaten (page 17) |
| Weak limbs, kinked spine, stopped climbing              | Advanced metabolic bone disease                    | Vet, lower the perches in the meantime (page 17)                       |
| Tail hanging over the head while resting inverted       | Floppy tail syndrome                               | Vet to rule out a calcium problem; add cork and foliage (page 17)      |
| No bowel movement for a week or more, bloated belly     | Impaction                                          | Warm soak; vet if it persists 24 to 48 hours (page 18)                 |
| Shed stuck on toes or the tail tip                      | Humidity cycle too dry, or dehydration             | Lukewarm soak and swab, fix the evening mist (page 18)                 |
| Open-mouth breathing, mucus, wheezing                   | Respiratory infection, from cold and constant damp | Vet; restore the daily dry-back and ventilation (page 18)              |
| Runny or foul stool for two days or more                | Internal parasites, diet change, stress            | Vet with a fresh sealed sample (page 19)                               |
| Sunken eyes, wrinkled skin, weak grip                   | Dehydration                                        | Check both humidity readings, mist, offer a hornworm (page 21)         |
| Refusing the diet powder, otherwise bright              | Pickiness, or husbandry out of range               | Rotate flavors, then check heat and humidity (page 10)                 |
| Eating and moving less through winter, weight steady    | Seasonal slowdown, not brumation                   | Keep weighing weekly; no cooling cycle (page 20)                       |
| Female restless, digging, plump, off food               | Gravid                                             | Lay box now; vet if straining passes 48 hours (page 15)                |
| Tail dropped                                            | Fright, rough handling, a fall, or a cagemate      | Keep the base clean and watch it; it will not grow back (page 19)      |
| One eye held closed, face rubbing                       | Retained shed or vitamin A deficiency              | Vet, do not touch the eye (page 19)                                    |
| Weight loss between log entries                         | Several possible causes                            | Vet, bring the Owner Log (page 30)                                     |

## Daily, weekly & seasonal routine

### Daily

- ☐ Mist in the evening as the lights go off, and check the hygrometer an hour later
- ☐ Fresh diet powder on the schedule for the gecko's age, and remove the old dish
- ☐ Fresh water, and a spot-clean of any stool
- ☐ Quick visual check: eyes full, skin smooth, gecko up in the structure after dark

### Weekly

- ☐ Weigh in grams and log it on page 30
- ☐ Offer insects, gut-loaded and dusted, on the day you have set
- ☐ Scrub the water and food dishes rather than just refilling them

### Monthly

- ☐ Full substrate change for a simple setup, or spot maintenance for a bioactive one
- ☐ Check every branch and ledge is still anchored, and review the Owner Log for trends

### Every 3 months

- ☐ Bioactive substrate change, and a supplement expiry check

### Seasonal

- ☐ Summer: plan for the hottest week now. Know how you will hold the room below 85°F (29°C)
- ☐ Winter: check the night low and watch for the seasonal slowdown, weighing weekly through it

### Yearly

- ☐ Wellness exam and a fecal test
- ☐ Replace the UVB tube, even if it still lights

#### WHAT A GOOD WEEK LOOKS LIKE

The hygrometer reading 60 to 80% an hour after the evening mist and 40 to 50% by mid-afternoon. Nothing in the enclosure over 85°F (29°C). Weight flat or climbing. The diet dish emptied rather than dried out. A gecko up in its branches after dark, gripping firmly, with clear full eyes.

#### IF YOU ONLY KEEP ONE HABIT

Keep the weekly weigh-in. Almost everything in Section 03 shows up as a weight change before it shows up as a symptom, and on an animal that tops out around 50 g a few grams is a lot. Sixty seconds, once a week, on a gram scale.

## Outages, heatwaves, travel & transport

Most reptile emergency plans are about losing heat. For this species the summer plan matters more than the winter one.

### When it gets too hot

- Move the enclosure out of the sun and away from exterior walls, to the coolest room in the house, usually the lowest floor.
- Get air moving. A fan across the room, not blasting into the enclosure, plus more of the screen top uncovered.
- Mist more often, in short bursts. Evaporation is the cooling you have.
- A frozen bottle wrapped in a towel, set beside the enclosure rather than inside it, buys a few degrees.
- Past 85°F (29°C) with a gecko that is gaping, limp or unresponsive, cool the room and call a vet the same day.

### When the power goes out

- Less urgent here than for a desert species. The normal night low is 65 to 72°F (18 to 22°C), and a cool night is not an emergency.
- Act if the room is heading for sustained temperatures at or below 72°F (22°C) day and night: lethargy and appetite loss follow.
- Drape towels over the enclosure leaving a vent gap, and keep misting by hand so humidity does not collapse with the mister offline.
- Don't use candles, gas stoves or open flame near the enclosure, and never put a heat pack in contact with the gecko.

### Leaving town

| TRIP LENGTH   | ADULT                                                                                                                 | JUVENILE                                                                |
|---------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1 to 2 nights | Usually fine alone. Fresh diet powder and water before you go, mister on a timer, lights on a timer.                  | A sitter once a day for fresh food, misting and a temperature check.    |
| 3 to 7 nights | A sitter every 1 to 2 days for fresh diet powder, misting, water and a temperature glance.                            | A sitter daily, with pre-measured diet powder and written instructions. |
| Over a week   | A daily sitter who has done a practice visit with you, or boarding with a reptile-experienced vet or specialist shop. |                                                                         |

A hand mister and a written misting time are the two things sitters most often get wrong for this species, because the humidity cycle is invisible in a way an empty food dish is not.

### Transport and vet trips

- A ventilated plastic tub with damp paper towel and a piece of cork to grip. No loose substrate, no open water dish, and keep it out of direct sun in the car.
- Never leave the gecko in a parked car, hot or cold. A closed car in summer passes this species' ceiling within minutes.
- Cool the car before loading in hot weather, and skip the meal beforehand.

## FILL IN AND LEAVE BY THE ENCLOSURE

# Pet-sitter sheet

Everything a sitter needs on one page. Walk them through it once in person before the first solo visit.

Gecko's name \_\_\_\_\_

Age and normal weight \_\_\_\_\_

My phone \_\_\_\_\_

Reptile vet \_\_\_\_\_

24-hour emergency clinic \_\_\_\_\_

Backup contact \_\_\_\_\_

## Each visit

- |                                                                                                    |                                                                                                      |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <input type="checkbox"/> Mist the walls, plants and cork in the evening until they are visibly wet | <input type="checkbox"/> Replace the diet powder on the days marked, and take the old dish out       |
| <input type="checkbox"/> Check the thermometer and hygrometer, and write both numbers down         | <input type="checkbox"/> Remove any stool and note whether it looked normal                          |
| <input type="checkbox"/> Fresh water in the shallow dish                                           | <input type="checkbox"/> Wash your hands before and after. Don't rinse anything in the kitchen sink. |

## Feeding while I'm away

Diet powder days \_\_\_\_\_

How much, and how to mix it \_\_\_\_\_

Misting time \_\_\_\_\_

Where everything is kept \_\_\_\_\_

## Please don't

- Take the gecko out, or touch the tail at all. It will drop, and it does not grow back.
- Change any dial, timer or thermostat setting, or move the enclosure into a sunnier room.
- Feed anything not on this sheet.

### CALL ME IF

The thermometer reads above 85°F (29°C), or the gecko is sitting low on the glass with its mouth open. The hygrometer never rises after misting. There is no stool across several visits. Breathing is audible or there is mucus at the nose. Anything is protruding from the vent. The tail has come off. If I don't answer, call the vet number above.

# Owner log

One row a week. Photocopy this page, or track digitally. Consistency matters more than the format.

| DATE | WEIGHT (G) | DAILY HIGH °F | HUMIDITY | APPETITE | STOOL | NOTES |
|------|------------|---------------|----------|----------|-------|-------|
|      |            |               |          |          |       |       |
|      |            |               |          |          |       |       |
|      |            |               |          |          |       |       |
|      |            |               |          |          |       |       |
|      |            |               |          |          |       |       |
|      |            |               |          |          |       |       |
|      |            |               |          |          |       |       |
|      |            |               |          |          |       |       |
|      |            |               |          |          |       |       |
|      |            |               |          |          |       |       |
|      |            |               |          |          |       |       |
|      |            |               |          |          |       |       |
|      |            |               |          |          |       |       |
|      |            |               |          |          |       |       |
|      |            |               |          |          |       |       |
|      |            |               |          |          |       |       |
|      |            |               |          |          |       |       |
|      |            |               |          |          |       |       |
|      |            |               |          |          |       |       |
|      |            |               |          |          |       |       |
|      |            |               |          |          |       |       |

## WHY BOTHER LOGGING

A gram scale is the most useful tool you can own for this species, and a steady weight trend is the best early warning system you have. Weight change usually appears well before any other symptom. Sixteen rows is four months, long enough to see a real trend rather than a bad week.

# Equipment, supplement & vet log

## Equipment log

| ITEM                                                | INSTALLED | REPLACE OR CHECK BY | DONE |
|-----------------------------------------------------|-----------|---------------------|------|
| UVB tube (replace every 12 months)                  |           |                     |      |
| Substrate (monthly, or 3 to 4 months bioactive)     |           |                     |      |
| Mister or fogger (check the timer monthly)          |           |                     |      |
| Thermometer and hygrometer batteries                |           |                     |      |
| Diet powder and supplements opened (replace yearly) |           |                     |      |

## Twelve-month planner

Tick the box in the month you did it. Start with whichever month you're in.

| TASK                       | M1                       | M2                       | M3                       | M4                       | M5                       | M6                       | M7                       | M8                       | M9                       | M10                      | M11                      | M12                      |
|----------------------------|--------------------------|--------------------------|--------------------------|--------------------------|--------------------------|--------------------------|--------------------------|--------------------------|--------------------------|--------------------------|--------------------------|--------------------------|
| Deep clean                 | <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> |
| Check perches are anchored | <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> |
| Supplement expiry check    | <input type="checkbox"/> |                          |                          | <input type="checkbox"/> |                          |                          | <input type="checkbox"/> |                          |                          | <input type="checkbox"/> |                          |                          |
| Vet exam                   | <input type="checkbox"/> |                          |                          |                          |                          |                          |                          |                          |                          |                          |                          | <input type="checkbox"/> |

## Vet visit log

| DATE | WEIGHT (G) | REASON AND FINDINGS | FOLLOW-UP |
|------|------------|---------------------|-----------|
|      |            |                     |           |
|      |            |                     |           |
|      |            |                     |           |
|      |            |                     |           |

## Enrichment checklist & log

### Setup

- ☐ A multi-level climbing network with real gaps between perches
- ☐ Dense foliage and several elevated hides at different heights
- ☐ An elevated feeding ledge, so the gecko never comes down to eat

### Monthly review

- ☐ Change one branch angle or rotate one plant. Leave the core structure alone
- ☐ Move the feeding station to a different ledge for a week
- ☐ Try one new safe food from pages 11 and 12

### Enrichment log

| DATE | ACTIVITY | HOW IT WENT, AND WHETHER TO REPEAT |
|------|----------|------------------------------------|
|      |          |                                    |
|      |          |                                    |
|      |          |                                    |
|      |          |                                    |
|      |          |                                    |
|      |          |                                    |
|      |          |                                    |
|      |          |                                    |
|      |          |                                    |

#### ENRICHMENT SAFETY

Anchor everything: a perch that shifts mid-jump is how a tail gets dropped, and it does not grow back. Never leave feeder insects loose overnight, never use wild-caught insects, and never overhaul the whole enclosure at once for a shy gecko. Nothing here substitutes for the temperature ceiling and the humidity cycle.

# Glossary

|                               |                                                                                                                                  |
|-------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Arboreal</b>               | Tree-dwelling. It is why height beats floor space, and why the food dish belongs on a ledge.                                     |
| <b>Autotomy</b>               | Voluntary tail loss. In a crested gecko it is permanent: the tail does not grow back. Page 19.                                   |
| <b>Bioactive</b>              | A living enclosure with a drainage layer, soil mix, leaf litter and a clean-up crew of springtails and isopods.                  |
| <b>CGD</b>                    | Crested gecko diet: the complete powdered food that forms the base of the diet. Page 10.                                         |
| <b>Crepuscular</b>            | Most active at dusk and after dark, which is why handling and feeding belong in the evening.                                     |
| <b>Dysecdysis</b>             | An abnormal or incomplete shed. Almost always a humidity problem in this species.                                                |
| <b>Dystocia</b>               | Egg binding: a female unable to pass eggs she has produced. A same-day veterinary problem. Page 15.                              |
| <b>Ecdysis</b>                | The normal shed cycle. Juveniles shed every one to two weeks, adults about monthly.                                              |
| <b>Ectotherm</b>              | An animal that takes its body heat from its environment. Here it means the room's temperature is the gecko's temperature.        |
| <b>Firing up and down</b>     | The normal color change between a dark, saturated active state and a pale resting one. Not a mood reading.                       |
| <b>Floppy tail syndrome</b>   | A tail that hangs over the head while the gecko rests inverted, associated with long-term sleeping on flat glass. Page 17.       |
| <b>Frogbutt</b>               | Keeper slang for a tailless crested gecko. Common, and not a welfare problem.                                                    |
| <b>Gut-loading</b>            | Feeding a feeder insect a calcium-rich diet for 24 to 48 hours before offering it, so the gecko eats the contents too. Page 11.  |
| <b>Hemipenal bulge</b>        | The paired swelling behind the vent that marks a male. Page 14.                                                                  |
| <b>Impaction</b>              | A blockage of the digestive tract, usually from loose substrate, oversized prey, or unpassed shed. Page 18.                      |
| <b>Metabolic bone disease</b> | Skeletal weakening from chronic calcium or vitamin D3 deficiency. Preventable, and partly permanent once advanced. Page 17.      |
| <b>Oxalic acid</b>            | A compound in spinach, beet greens and chard that binds calcium into an unusable form, which is why they are the wrong gut-load. |
| <b>Urate</b>                  | The soft white portion passed alongside stool: a reptile's version of urine. Hard and yellow means dehydrated.                   |
| <b>Wet-dry cycle</b>          | The daily humidity swing, 60 to 80% after misting down to 40 to 50% by day. The target is the swing, not a fixed number. Page 7. |

## REFERENCE

# Sources

Where the numbers in this package come from, so you can check them yourself.

## Veterinary and scientific sources

- PetMD: Crested Gecko Care Sheet, and Egg Binding in Reptiles. Shedding frequency, common health issues, the conservative 80°F caution, and the fact that females produce eggs with no male present.
- Merck Veterinary Manual: Overview of Reptiles, for lizard sexing by preanal pores and hemipenal bulges; management and husbandry of reptiles, and the parasitic and routine health care pages, for thermostat control, the 3 to 6 month quarantine on page 25, and what urates are.
- VCA Animal Hospitals: Reptiles, Gout, for what a discolored urate is warning about on page 21.
- LafeberVet: Reproductive Disease in Reptiles, for inadequate nesting as a cause of egg retention and the calcium demand of a reproductively active female.
- Chromosome-level genome assembly of the crested gecko, *Correlophus ciliatus*, a lizard incapable of tail regeneration (PMC), for permanent tail loss.
- Centers for Disease Control and Prevention: reptiles and amphibians, and the *Salmonella* Muenchen outbreak linked to pet geckos, closed January 2026. Page 8.
- Center for Food Security and Public Health, Iowa State University: Reptile- and Amphibian-Associated Salmonellosis.
- Association of Reptilian and Amphibian Veterinarians (ARAV): find-a-vet directory.

## Husbandry references

- ReptiFiles Crested Gecko Care Sheet, republished by Zen Habitats: temperatures including the 65 to 72°F night range, the humidity range and wet-dry cycle, enclosure sizing, substrate depth, feeding frequency and time to maturity.
- ReptiFiles: Crested Gecko Temperatures and Humidity, and the crested gecko shopping list, for the 85°F ceiling and setup costs.
- The Vet Desk: crested gecko cost breakdown.
- Beastly Facts guides, current at publication: the crested gecko tank setup, humidity, feeding, health issues, handling, cost and enrichment guides, plus the cross-species reptile quarantine, salmonella and hygiene, stool and urates, heating and thermostats, shedding and emergency plan guides.

Where sources genuinely disagree this package prints the range rather than picking a side. Adult size is the clearest case, from 5 to 8 in and 35 to 45 g in some references to 7 to 9 in and 35 to 55 g in others. The temperature ceiling is the other: 85°F (29°C) is the widely used hard maximum, while one veterinary care sheet warns against sustained exposure above 80°F (27°C). Raspberries are listed as safe by some sources and as high-oxalate by others, and page 12 says so rather than choosing.

REFERENCE

# Version history & about

What changed, and when, so an older printout can be placed.

## Version history

| VERSION        | TEMPLATE | WHAT CHANGED                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
|----------------|----------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 2.1 · Sep 2026 | t3       | Cross-checked against the September 2026 cross-species reptile articles. Page 25 ended quarantine on a clear fecal result; it now runs the Merck window of 3 to 6 months, with the point that a single negative sample is one snapshot of an intermittent process. Page 8 carries the 2026 CDC pet-gecko outbreak and the full hygiene rules. Page 21's normal-stool row now says a fruit-powder diet makes for a softer stool than a strict insectivore's, so softer is not automatically wrong, and the discolored-urate row names the urate and kidney problem behind it with misting as the correction an arboreal species actually needs. Sources and version history split onto their own pages. |
| 2.0 · Sep 2026 | t3       | Rebuilt and expanded from 21 to 34 pages. Metric units throughout, a misting and ventilation page with the humidity cycle, separate complete-diet, insect and fruit charts, sexing and growth, females and egg binding, split condition pages, poop and hydration, a heatwave and outage plan, a pet-sitter sheet, longer logs, a glossary and this page. Supplement guidance corrected so nothing is dusted into the complete diet powder.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| 1.0 · 2026     | pre-t3   | First edition, 21 pages, on the earlier layout.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |

**WHERE THIS PACKAGE AND THE SITE DISAGREE, AND THE PACKAGE IS RIGHT**

Page 28 gives the normal night low as 65 to 72°F (18 to 22°C). The site's reptile emergency plan guide lists 70 to 75°F for this species in its temperature table. The care sheet both draw on gives 65 to 72°F as the nighttime figure and 70 to 75°F as the daytime cool-area figure, so the article has carried a daytime number into a night row. Page 28 keeps the correct one. The action figure, sustained at or below 72°F day and night, matches on both sides.

This package is a husbandry reference compiled from the sources on page 34 and cross-checked against current veterinary guidance at the time of publication. It is not a substitute for a reptile-experienced veterinarian, and nothing in it should delay a vet visit. Free companion guides are at [beastlyfacts.com](#).

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